Thirukkural and Thiruvalluvar

Introduction to the Thirukkural

The Thirukkural, also called the Kural or Muppal, is one of the greatest works of Tamil literature and one of the most widely translated ancient texts in the world. It was written by the poet and philosopher Thiruvalluvar and consists of short two-line verses, called kurals, on how to live a good life, how to govern wisely and how to love. The word "kural" means short, and the verse form is called kural venba: each couplet has seven words, with four in the first line and three in the second, which makes it extremely compact. The work is called the "Universal Veda" (Ulaga Podhu Marai) and the "Tamil Veda", because its teachings apply to everyone regardless of religion, caste, nation or time, and it never mentions a specific god, region or community.

How Many Kurals Are in the Thirukkural?

The Thirukkural contains 1,330 kurals (couplets). They are organised into 133 chapters, called adhikarams, with ten couplets in each chapter. Each chapter treats a single theme such as friendship, education, hospitality, gratitude, self-control or agriculture.

What Are Its Three Sections?

The Thirukkural is divided into three sections, called paals, which correspond to the three goals of human life as described in ancient Indian thought. The first section is Aram (Arathuppal), on virtue or ethics, which has 38 chapters and 380 kurals. It deals with personal virtue, household life, duties of the householder, compassion, non-killing, truthfulness and the renunciant's life. The second section is Porul (Porutpal), on wealth, polity and governance, and it has 70 chapters and 700 kurals. It covers the qualities of rulers, ministers, the army, justice, taxation, friendship, diplomacy, agriculture and economic life. The third section is Inbam, also known as Kamattuppal, on love and human emotions, and it has 25 chapters and 250 kurals. It describes the love between a man and a woman in poetic form, through the stages of union and separation, using the conventions of Tamil love poetry. In total, 38 plus 70 plus 25 equals 133 chapters, and 380 plus 700 plus 250 equals 1,330 kurals. The three sections together are the reason for the title Muppal, "the three-part book". Some other translations call the third part Kamam.

Who Was Thiruvalluvar?

Very little is known with certainty about Thiruvalluvar's life. Traditions say that he was a weaver by profession who lived in Mylapore in Madras (Chennai), and that his wife was Vasuki, who was known for her devotion and obedience. Scholars date him between the 1st century BCE and the 5th or 6th century CE, with many placing him around the 1st to 3rd centuries CE, or the 5th century. His work is counted among the "Eighteen Minor Works" (Pathinenkilkanakku) of Tamil literature. The Government of Tamil Nadu officially follows the Thiruvalluvar Aandu, a Tamil calendar year that is the Gregorian year plus 31, which in 2026 would be 2057 and which counts from 31 BCE, the year assigned by Maraimalai Adigal and others as Thiruvalluvar's birth. Thiruvalluvar Day is celebrated in Tamil Nadu in January, on the day after Pongal. The temple dedicated to Thiruvalluvar is in Mylapore, Chennai, and a Thiruvalluvar Day is also observed in other parts of the world.

Teachings and Famous Ideas

The Thirukkural begins with a chapter in praise of God and another on the greatness of rain, and it famously stresses ahimsa (non-violence), truthfulness, gratitude, charity, hospitality, humility and self-control. It speaks about education as the true wealth, and says that learning is a lifelong treasure. It says that a good government depends on justice, and that rulers should listen to criticism. It praises farming, saying that the world follows the farmer. It says that friendship is not about frequent meetings but about the shared feelings of hearts, and that gratitude should never be forgotten. It also teaches the idea that character is higher than birth, and that all people are equal by birth, with differences arising from deeds. The ethics of the Thirukkural are relevant today to governance, business, family life, education and personal integrity.

Translations and Global Recognition

The Thirukkural has been translated into more than 40 languages, including English, French, German, Latin, Russian, Chinese, Hindi and Sinhala. The first Latin translation was made by the Italian missionary Constanzo Beschi (Veeramamunivar) in 1730, and the English translation by the Rev. G. U. Pope in 1886 and translations by V. V. S. Aiyar, C. Rajagopalachari and others made it famous. Leo Tolstoy and Mahatma Gandhi admired it, and Albert Schweitzer praised its ethics. The Tamil Nadu government displays kurals in public buses, and the Kural is also quoted by leaders worldwide. The Government of India issued a commemorative stamp, and a bust of Thiruvalluvar has been installed at the School of Oriental and African Studies in London.

Where Is the Thiruvalluvar Statue?

The famous Thiruvalluvar statue is located at Kanyakumari, at the southern tip of India, where the Arabian Sea, the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean meet, on a small rocky island near the Vivekananda Rock Memorial. The statue is 133 feet (about 40.6 metres) tall, standing on a 38-foot pedestal, so the figure itself is 95 feet high. The height of 133 feet represents the 133 chapters of the Thirukkural, the 38-foot pedestal stands for the 38 chapters of the section on virtue (Aram), and the 95-foot figure stands for the 95 chapters of wealth and love together. It was designed by the architect V. Ganapati Sthapati and carved from granite, and was unveiled by Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi on 1 January 2000. The statue survived the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami. Another notable monument is the Valluvar Kottam in Chennai, built in 1976, which has the form of a temple chariot with all 1,330 kurals inscribed on granite pillars in the hall, and a statue of Thiruvalluvar.

Commentaries and Influence

Ancient scholars wrote commentaries on the Kural, with Parimelazhagar's 13th-century commentary being the most respected. The Thirukkural influenced later Tamil poets such as Bharathiyar and Bharathidasan, as well as reformers such as Periyar and Gandhi. Poet Subramania Bharati wrote that Tamil Nadu gained fame in the world by giving birth to Valluvar.

Challenges and Future

Scholars still debate his date, religion and life. In modern times the Kural is being promoted through digital apps, school competitions and translations in many Indian and foreign languages.

Quick Facts

- The Thirukkural has 1,330 kurals in 133 chapters of 10 couplets each.
- Its three sections are Aram (virtue, 380 kurals), Porul (wealth and polity, 700 kurals) and Inbam (love, 250 kurals).
- The 133-foot Thiruvalluvar statue is at Kanyakumari, unveiled on 1 January 2000.
- Thiruvalluvar is traditionally linked to Mylapore, Chennai.
- Constanzo Beschi made the first Latin translation in 1730; G. U. Pope's English translation came in 1886.